

Train Your Show Dog

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Introduction

Our dogs have so many potentials and skills that we could find so many ways to tap into them. While some dogs express themselves in races, not all of our beloved pooches could run the race track without any harm coming upon them. Thus we need to let our imagination travel and see our precious pooch getting that much coveted ribbon! Where better to win that ribbon but in a dog show?

Mankind has always been close with dogs and been breeding them for ages. Thus, dog breeding has come a long way and through the years produced breeds that have unique physical appearance and traits much to the delight of everyone. And since we have always been in awe with the things around us and pretty much want to let everyone know what beautiful things we have, gave rise even most towns and cities have like livestock shows, cat shows and of course, dog shows.

A show dog may come from any dog breeds and the show aims to find the best aesthetic quality, bloodlines and training, and trainers come from different backgrounds and lifestyles/ but despite the differences, these trainers have only one goal: to be the best in the field!

One could have an option to hire trainers or handlers for their beloved pooch but nothing beats the feeling to handling your own dog. And with this experience, bond between dog and master is further strengthened. The dog comes to trust the handler and the handler comes to trust the dog, with this, they become an unbeatable team.

Just as diverse as the breeds are the shows since shows differ in types, nature and location. While most shows are indoors, some are outdoors or even in large spaces or arena. Still some shows may only cater to purebreds or specifically, to only one certain breed wherein they are being chosen based on certain criteria. These shows have certain tests to prove the breed to be an excellent one. obstacle courses and obedience tests are being included in the shows to show just how exemplary a dog is and just how great the trainer/handler is.

Shows dogs compete in shows organized by clubs or organizations. In America, the oldest organization which organizes dog shows goes by the name Kennel Club which was established in 1877. This is where one could see purebred dogs in their excellent shape.

Dog Shows

The dogs are entered in to a competition by their trainers or handlers and these are popularly known as “Dog Shows” wherein there is elimination at certain rounds after they fail to meet the standard required per round. Just like most contests, the final round determines which dog is worthy to be declared as the winner. The highest award that could be given to a participant is often a title called “Best in Show”.

Why the need for dog shows? Since dogs are man’s best friend, we value their aesthetic merit and human as we are, appreciate the beauty of our dogs. These factors gave rise to a show being put together to showcase the talents and beauty of our beloved pets.

The goal of these shows is to steal the audience. It is not an assurance that more expensive dogs often times win the competition. Any dog owner could enter their dog as long they meet the standards required in the competition.

Upon entering the competition, dogs are classified according to breeds. Those having similar traits, physical appearance and characteristics are grouped. They could either be Large, Small and Fancy .Likewise, age is also a basis for classifying dogs. They could be classified as puppy or adult. This is very vital since puppies have not yet met the ideal standard set often times the basis of which those for adults. This does not mean puppies could no longer join.

Just like any shows, it begins with the breed specific competition. Dogs under the same breed compete with each other at different levels of judging. Unique to each breed is their breeding standard which will be used to judge them. Now bear in mind that the criteria used for large breeds will not be applicable to fancy breeds thus the need for breed specific judging prior.

When facing judgement, the dogs must meet the standards looked for in their breed. These standards include ideal breed size and ideal breed personality. Sometimes, dogs are eliminated for being too unruly and disobedient in the show proper. Thus they must pass both the ideal standard and specification for each breed lest they be eliminated from the competition.

Often times, dog show ribbons increases the value and worth of the offspring sired by champion dogs or born from champion mothers. This is most commonly reason why some pet owners enter their pets with the hope of winning that much coveted “Best in Show”.

I’m a beginner, now what?

Taking part in a dog show is no easy task. This requires careful planning and study. The moment you decide to be part of the dog show, your choice of breed and breeder already determines how you will fare in the future. Ask the breeder all the questions you could think of

before deciding on that breed. Read as much as you can on the topic and search for more informative materials.

As you prepare, it's advisable to visit the shows, especially the ones which caters to your chosen breed, for you to be familiar with the different things happening during the show proper. This could help increase your knowledge with the breed selected. Be a keen observer. Observe how the dogs were handled, how the handlers carry themselves and the atmosphere inside the ring. Very important as well is to observe how the judges do the judging. This will help when you train your dog.

The moment you made your choice, the show training starts as well. As the time passes, your puppy will try to adjust with you and the new surroundings. It will be naughty and this is a good time to start bonding with it and start making it obedient. Try not to use force or any harmful methods as this traumatize your puppy. Give it time to fully learn what you are teaching. Try to make it friendly and comfortable with other people. This will help in the future during the show.

When it is a few weeks old, start training it for the show as this help him develop confidence as time progresses. One tricky thing is making it comfortable standing. Judges will want dogs standing still as they examine it. Try putting your right on its belly and the left hand on its chin. This will do the trick.

Reward the dog. For every correct move, command obeyed, praise your pet. Some people give rewards but this is not always recommended as this will not be useful when food runs out. A simple voice trick is the key. Dogs respond to voice and our actions. Showing them how happy we are always has positive results.

Maintain good grooming. Learn from the experts. A well groomed dog is always favoured in the show. See to it that it well maintained and well groomed. His coat must be shiny, soft and smooth. Know how to play the coat of your dog to your advantage.

Lastly, discipline. Discipline for dogs is very important for them to know what needs to be done. If it is time for work then they have to work and if it's playtime they can play all they want. So, they can be playful and funny when with you but is careful enough not to fight and mess around with other dogs in the area.

Training your Dogs

Every dog owner would want their dogs to steal the audience during a show. But before it could happily trot to victory, it needs to be trained for the stage seal the success. Pretty much, people get handlers to train their dogs for them but as pet owners we could also train our dogs. After all, we already have that bond with them.

Training them is fairly simple as long as you have the determination and patience to do so. Trained dogs are not made overnight, they are product of practice and time. A simplified training procedure yet productive if properly done is extremely helpful for beginners and starters.

- **Local ring craft class.**

- A ring craft class will be a big help in training your dog for a show. Although this is not necessary this is highly recommended as this is where often times trainers help dogs help for the show.

- **Stack or to stand squarely and still**

- Breeds could either be “free stacked” (handler standing in front while dog stands alert and still) or “hand stacked” (each leg placed manually in position while handler stands or kneels). Choose one that best fits your dog and be consistent in training. Judges consider how your dog stands. The dog has to stay in position for at least 2-3 minutes at a time or as prescribed by the judges. Dogs must feel accustomed to strangers touching them.

- **Gaiting**

- Practice your dog to move in a way their movements and structure could be seen by the judge. This is often times called gaiting. Trotting is the correct pace since it shows the dog’s real structure the best. Adjust the pace of your dog according to its size. They will take time to adjust to correct speed and direction but practice is the key.

- **Expression**

- We all want our dog to look happy, alert and beautiful when stacked. Almost all breeds must have their attention caught by the handler and likewise focus on the judge. The lead/collar and the bait are the tricks to do this. Collar keeps the dog still while the bait quickly gets its attention.

- **Practice Group**

- On the day of the contest, dogs not familiar with other dogs and people will be a major problem not only for the owner but also for everyone present in the area. Find a practice class or have fun matches for that matter. They are great for aspiring judges and practice for your dog.

- **Go over**

- Physical appearance of your dogs, its ears, teeth, feet and tail, are often times examined. It will be asked to pick up its feet, lift its tail and its testicles will be felt. The dogs must get used to this as this will be done during the show. He must be used to strangers touching him.

Taking Care of Your Show dog

- ✓ There are two factors to consider, when it comes to taking care of our show dogs and that is health and nutrition. Show dogs are not just dogs, they 1st and foremost your pets and part of your family. Even after the shows, they are still your pets and your best buds. Some dogs consider their pet owners as family and will do anything for them. Just don't abuse this kind of bond.
- ✓ They are pretty much all about in routine in nature meaning that they day to day is, if possible, must not be outside their known routine. Sticking to a certain routine will develop your dog's good habit and thus making it easier to train and discipline them.
- ✓ See to it that when you feed them, the time should be constant and uniform. It should be noted that after eating, he must be sent to the potty to ensure bowel movements as this is very essential during the shows and while on travel.
- ✓ Every pet owner wants to have a clean coat pet, thus the liberty to bathe the dogs when dirty. But this is not the case for show dogs. They do not have the coats that could be cleaned anytime. Attention must be given whenever their coat is dirty. A good scrub for an ordinary pet is great but not so for any show dog. Certain breeds must meet with the standards set by the show or judges.
- ✓ Exercise with your dog. Their muscles and feet may need exercise especially if they are competing for a show. Let your dogs run and trot all they want each day to flex and stretch those muscles. Just be careful of where they are as they tend to be very curious. We don't want our show dogs injured.
- ✓ Diet is vital as this will determine the over-all health condition of the dog. Always follow what is recommended for them unless otherwise you are an expert on that field. Show dogs need nutritious food just as much as an ordinary pet. Just be sure that it is not overweight or fat.
- ✓ Proper nutrition without proper health is useless. This is a great responsibility for the dog owner. Be sure that it is properly vaccinated and a constant visit to the

veterinarian is a must. Treat the dogs for ticks and lice as well. There is no better show dog than a healthy one.

Feeding Your Dog

If you think that only people are particular with their food, dogs are too! Animal nutritionists devote their time and effort in making the best dog food for our beloved pooch. We cannot just feed show dogs any food we deem edible by them. They require nutritional and quality food. And remember, some show dogs may not be allowed to eat certain food as this will affect their coat. Reading on what food is best for them is highly recommended but if you don't like reading, you could always consult your vet.

Remember however those most commercial dog foods are made from materials unusable or less desirable for human consumption. These may include:

- Meat by-products or digests
- Meat-and-bone meals
- Grain by-products
- Restaurant grease

Less expensive foods generally include less meat, and more meat by-products and grain "fillers". The most expensive dog's foods may be made of ingredients suitable for human consumption, organic products or free-range meats. Allergic skin disease, obesity, food intolerance, inflammatory bowel disease, chronic ear infections, cystitis (bladder inflammation), bladder and kidney stones, certain heart diseases, pancreatitis, feline hyperthyroidism, hip dysplasia, canine mammary cancer, bloat, and diabetes all have nutritional components - that is, nutritional factors are suspected or known to play a role in inducing or perpetuating these diseases. We must then pay close attention to what we are feeding our animals and how they are reacting to the food.

Take time to visit your local veterinarian when feeding show dogs. They always know and will recommend what food to give your dog and other useful tips for your dogs. Dogs must be in excellent health when they come to the show ring. Their coat and expression will tell a lot if they are not properly fed.

Nowadays, we have so many choices when it comes to food. Just make sure that the food we select for them will cater to their needs. Don't hesitate to ask your friends and other dog owners about feeding dogs.

Types of Dog Show

Dog shows vary from each other. Some are held indoor, at an arena or a field and some at small and confined spaces. The location depends upon the nature of the show since large dog breeds requires bigger spaces as compared to smaller ones. So, if one wishes to enter their dogs at a certain show, it is better to know first what shows there are and their nature.

Choosing a show is very important if we want to win. One cannot enter their pet at just any dog shows and win immediately. Just like when choosing what dog to own and love, careful selection must be done. It is advisable to read the books or some articles pertaining to the nature of the show selected. Also, it does not hurt to call and ask the organizer of the show as to what is the nature of their show, what are the prizes, breeds that could join (some shows cater to certain breeds only) and the venue.

So, what are the most common types of shows?

- Test and Trials
 - Certain dog breeds are in nature sporty. How so? Breeds like German shepherd and Doberman are high jumpers, agile and fast runners. Golden Retrievers and Labradors are known for their love of discs and jumping. Terriers are known for their obedience. Whatever their training or instincts are, they are judge as to how they are able to deliver what is required from them. This show allows the both the dogs and spectators to enjoy the activity. Regardless of how they were trained, the dogs and their trainers must prove to the spectators its obedience and what it can do. Also, one can see dogs in action. Most common examples of these shows include dog sports and earth dog trials.
- Fun Shows
 - Dog shows likewise could be used as fundraisers. If some people opt for dinner as fundraisers, some choose dog shows. Charities organize dog shows as they are appealing to young and old alike. Unique are their awards since the give prizes to things often time overlooked in some shows. Their awards include most obedient dog, smallest dog, youngest dog, look-alike and best in costumes. Sometimes they cater to young audiences than adults.
- Conformation Shows

- In this shows, we see champion breeds and experts on specific breeds. Purebreds are the most common entries and they carefully judged by experts. Often times judging is done individually giving importance to the conformity of the dog the breed standard. Both handler and dogs undergo judging during the show and appearance especially accurate dog grooming is demanded.

Dog Show Categories

As quoted in the American Kennel Club, it is vital to know what the club's standards are.

“Only the *Best of Breed* winners advance to compete in the Group competitions. Each AKC-recognized breed falls into one of seven group classifications. The seven groups are Sporting, Hound, Working, Terrier, Toy, Non-Sporting and Herding. Four placements are awarded in each group, but only the first-place winner advances to the Best in Show competition.

The Seven Groups in All-Breed Shows

1. Sporting

These dogs were bred to hunt game birds both on land and in the water. The breeds in this group include Pointers, Retrievers, Setters and Spaniels.

2. Hounds

These breeds were bred for hunting other game by sight or scent. These breeds include such dogs as Beagles, Bassets, Dachshunds and Greyhounds.

3. Working

These dogs were bred to pull carts, guard property and perform search and rescue services. Among the breeds in this group are the Akita, Boxer, Doberman Pinscher and St. Bernard.

4. Terrier

This group includes breeds such as the Airedale, Cairn Terrier and Scottish Terrier. Terriers were bred to rid property of vermin such as rats.

5. Toy

These dogs were bred to be household companions. This group includes little dogs such as the Chihuahua, Maltese, Pomeranian and Pug.

6. Non-Sporting

This diverse group includes the Chow Chow, Bulldog, Dalmatian and Poodle. These dogs vary in size and function, and many are considered companion dogs.

7. Herding

These dogs were bred to help shepherds and ranchers herd their livestock. The Briard, Collie, German Shepherd Dog and Old English sheepdog are some of the breeds in this group.

Finally, the seven group winners are brought into the ring where they compete for Best in Show, the highest award at a dog show.

Ribbons

Each dog that receives an award is given a ribbon by the judge. The color of the ribbon indicates the type of award the dog has won.

1. Blue

- Awarded to the first place in any regular class. Also awarded to the winner of each group competition, usually in the form of a "rosette".

2. Red

- Awarded to the second place in each class. Also awarded for second place in each group competition, usually in the form of a "rosette".

3. Yellow

- Awarded to third place in each class. Also awarded for third place in each group competition, usually in the form of a "rosette".

4. White

- Awarded to the fourth place in each class. The award given to the fourth place is also in the form of "rosette"

5. Purple

- Awarded to the winners of the Winners Dog and Winners Bitch classes. Since these are the classes in which championship points are earned, these ribbons are highly coveted.

6. Purple and White

- Awarded to the Reserve Winners; that is, the runners-up to the winner of the Winners Dog and Winners Bitch classes.

7. Blue and White

- Awarded to the dog that wins Best of Winners; that is, the better of the Winners Dog and Winners Bitch winners.

8. Purple and Gold

- Awarded to the dog judged "Best of Breed" in each breed competition. This is highly coveted because it allows advancement to the Group competition.

9. Red and White

- Awarded to the Best of Opposite Sex. This means the best dog of the breed that is the opposite sex of the Best of Breed winner. “
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What is being judged?

Every show, breeding clubs and registries have set up standards which will be later used in judging during shows or competitions. Division is always practiced as dogs may be divided and sorted by sex or size. Sometimes they are sorted into classes which include puppy, open class or breed. Still they could be further broken down depending on the discretion of the judges or organizers.

Judges carefully examine each dog in the class given a certain set of parameters as prescribed in the breed's official standard. The characteristics are described in the standard and discuss the specification included in each like structure, temperament and movement. Experts are often the judges for the shows. It is important that only experts be judges as they only know what to look for and check in dogs.

The judges see to it that they could see what they want to see. They check the body and structure and do a “go over” with each dog with their hands. This is done to check if the set breed standards are met by the dogs as evidenced by teeth, muscle, bones and coat. This is why it is stressed that dogs already be used to strangers touching them. Dogs uncomfortable being touched will pose a serious threat to the judges.

Balance is extremely important in judging. When dogs gait, the judges will see and check the balance and structure of the body. Gait will also see the movement is in harmony with the

body and structure. Often times, the judges will ask the handlers or pet owners to trot their dogs to carefully check the gait. The best way to see how they all fit is to see the dog in motion.

From these classes, winners will be chosen such as Best Puppy, Best Female, Best Male or other awards. From these, the winner will compete against other winners for the honor “Best in Breed”. The “Best in Breed” winners from each group will each go the semi final round where they will compete with other dogs in the group. Usually, around six to seven dogs remain to compete for the “Best in Show” award.

Why Smaller breeds?

When starting at a dog show, it is better start with smaller breeds as they are easier to handle and train compared to larger breeds which require more time and larger space. Small dogs only need small space, less time and easier to train. Smaller breeds requires less attention as compared to larger ones which makes the pet owner to own more than one breed at a time without having to worry that their needs will be neglected.

Small dogs like Pugs, Chihuahuas, Toy Poodles and terriers are the favoured choice of breeds. They are small, obedient and mild tempered and most especially easy to train that their large counterparts. Likewise, small is less. This means that small dogs require only small crates when transporting them from one place to another. Also, this makes it comfortable for the one handling them and feels at ease when handling them. Usually it is the owners themselves who handle their own dog given the relaxed situation.

Smaller breeds means that even children could join the dog shows and start at an early age the practice of dog shows. This an educational activity for the young and old alike since they could pretty much learn a lot and this could also serve as the bonding activity for parents and children alike. The time spent for one large breed could be utilized for more than one small breed.

New dog show participants find it easy and advantageous to have smaller dog breeds than large ones as they are easy to manage. In some shows where they require dogs to be bathe and groom, it is realized that one dog owner could finish at five to six dogs. Lesser time consumed as compared to large ones. Also, when grooming them, less space is consumed since one table may cater to two dogs if the two get along well just as easily.

When having small dogs, it is not as strenuous to the handler when it is required for the dog to trot as their strides are not as great as that compared to the large breeds. This makes the handler not to exert extra effort in keeping pace with the dogs since both strides could pretty much be similar in distance. It can be noted that the atmosphere between the two is more relaxed as compared to large breeds.

What to do on the Big Day

On the big day, come early like an hour or 30 minutes before the scheduled time. This will help your dog settle in the venue prior to the start of the show. It is understandable that when you arrive at the competition your beloved dog is perfectly groomed. Very important as well is your dog coat if he has long coats. Make sure that you have combed its coat before going to the show.

When making sure that your dog is well groomed, take note of its breed. There is a difference in the amount of equipment you will need depending on the breed that you have. Poodles require a lot more expertise and equipment to groom than German Shorthairs. A minimum requirement for most people is a grooming table and a kit with brushes, wipe rags, etc.

Bring water bottles and containers for your dogs. As the show progresses, your dog will be thirsty and restless. Have water on hand so that you could always give your dogs when they become thirsty. Be mindful of your water and make sure that you store them in a secure place. Nothing beats a cautious pet owner during a show. Sometime one cannot avoid that some pet owners will do whatever they can to make their dogs win.

For you, wearing appropriate clothing and comfortable clothes during the show will be of importance. You cannot wear formal clothes during dog sports or heels during earth dog trials.

Once you have settled, secure a catalogue to get information about the show and about other breeds, handlers and nature of the succeeding events.

Document your win most especially if the win is something worth the points. A blue ribbon or better is definitely something you want to get on film. This will also support your win in case some documents or records are lost.

Watch your dog at all times, outside and inside the ring, coz even if your dog is a “good dog”, other dogs may not be. Be on the lookout for restless and unruly dogs. You don’t want your dogs to be affected by them.

Nothing beats a good investment in crate. This will be very important in carrying your dogs to and from the ring. Always bear in mind the size of your dog as this will determine the kind of crate to be bought. Make sure that your dogs are comfortable in their crates so that it could give them the much needed air.

What Goes on in a Dog Show?

The AKC (American Kennel Club) is the one that sets the standards for the show. To fully understand what really goes on during the show, a clip of the rules of the AKC is provided. Nothing is much clearer than reading the standards set by them.

Males and females compete separately within their respective breeds, in seven regular classes. The following classes are offered, and are divided by sex:

- Puppy - dogs between six and twelve months of age that are not yet champions (optional class).
- Twelve-To-Eighteen Months - dogs twelve to eighteen months of age that are not yet champions (optional class).
- Novice - dogs six months of age and over, which have not, prior to the date of closing of entries, won three first prizes in the Novice Class, a first prize in Bred-by-Exhibitor, American-bred, or Open Classes, nor one or more points toward their championship (optional class).
- Amateur-Owner-Handler – dogs that are at least six months of age that are not champions. Dogs must be handled in the class by the registered owner of the dog and is limited to exhibitors who have not, at any point in time, been a professional dog handler, AKC approved conformation judge, or employed as an assistant to a professional handler (effective January 1, 2009) (optional class).
- Bred By Exhibitor - dogs that are exhibited by their owner and breeder, that are not yet champions (optional class).
- American-Bred - dogs born in the United States from a mating which took place in the United States, that are not yet champions (mandatory class).
- Open - dog of any breed, at least 6 months of age (mandatory class).

After these classes are judged, all the dogs that won first place in a class compete again to see whose dog is the best among the winning dogs. Males and females are judged separately. Only the best male (Winners Dog) and the best female (Winners Bitch) receive championship points. The Winners Dog and Winners Bitch then compete with the champions for the Best of Breed award. At the end of the Best of Breed Competition, three awards are usually given:

Best of Breed - the dog judged as the best in its breed category.

Best of Winners - the dog judged as the better of the Winners Dog and Winners Bitch.

Best of Opposite Sex - the best dog that is the opposite sex to the Best of Breed winner.

Dog shows follow a process of elimination, with one dog being named best in Show at the end of the show.

How Can I know What Show Dog is for me?

The moment you take home a puppy you already have decided what show it will be competing in. How a puppy looks will not be the major consideration as most puppies will look really cute and cuddly at that age. But as soon as it grows and mature, that cute and cuddly look will disappear. It might be a problem once you have made a wrong choice.

Make sure that in choosing the breed it must be the right one for you. Even if you like certain breed but unsure if you could take care of it, don't force the issue of getting that puppy. Large and small breeds have their pros and cons. Some large breeds may move slowly but they need large space while small breeds are mischievous but could be confined in a small space.

Again and again, knowledge is power. A knowledgeable aspiring dog owner is more likely to get the much wanted breed to be enjoined at the dog shows. With the technology today, we have the knowledge at our fingertips. We could always read and request for information from various breeders club and experts online. One could also visit the local canine clubs for their expert advice on what breed to chose and buy.

You may consult dog owners also for the breed you are interested. They could give you the information that you want. They could help you as they have experience from their long years of taking care dogs and pets. They could give information often not discussed in books or by vets. They could be your mentor in choosing and selecting show dogs.

Once you have made your decision, be sure that once you bring a puppy home, everything is already prepared so as to not shock the puppy and stress it on its first few days. Treat it with care especially during the first few weeks which are vital when we want to create that special bond with our puppy. As it grows mature, the training for shows starts. Some train their puppies even when it is just weeks old to familiarize the puppy with the different things happening inside the ring.

Bear in mind that once you buy a puppy, always check for its papers. When owning a show dog the papers very important especially when tracing the pedigree of you puppy or dog. The papers also inform as to the vaccination and health issues of the puppy.

Selecting a Dog Show

Being new in the field, you don't have much experience and knowledge on the show. This is just natural as almost every dog show expert has been through that process as well. Questions upon questions will be playing on your mind as the big day approaches.

One key to being good in the show is proper knowledge and the guts to ask help form other dog owners. It's best to ask advice from those dog owners who have been in the shows for

years. They will give you advice on what show is best for beginners. From this, gain as much experience as you can and as time progresses, you will be prepared for more challenging shows.

In choosing a show, read books for further info especially on your dog's breed. Try to know the schedule of the dog shows as the start of the year. This will give you the idea as to the preparation time in preparing your dog for the big event. As a starter and a newbie, you might have to look for the schedules yourself but if you're already part of a breeder club, the club itself will provide you of the schedule.

When choosing a show, don't go after the awards you will get but instead try to know if your dog could meet the standards being asked in the show. It will be an extreme waste of time and effort preparing for a show that your dog will not be able to compete.

Don't hesitate to ask organizers reading their show. The more you ask questions the more knowledge you will gain on the field. These organizers will be more than happy to answer your questions. Attend shows prior to joining one, this will give you an idea of what to expect during a show. This is what your other future competitors might actually be doing. As you attend shows, they are announcing the upcoming schedules of their future shows and thus will give you the idea of the time and give you ample time to prepare for a target show.

You could also check for details and schedule online. Don't rush in joining when you are not yet ready. Careful planning and selection is extremely vital. More or less, a year is enough to gain that much needed knowledge and experience. And by this time, you will be well equipped to face the other owners.

What to remember

Nothing beats practice. This is the most important aspect when preparing for a show. It is very advisable to bring your dogs to the ring every day. Walk them around the ring to make them feel comfortable and at ease when it comes to the big day. Familiarity with rings and this shape of it will ensure you and your dog a trouble-free show. Likewise, hold them like what you would do when you are holding them during the big day. Take note of what pacing is most suitable for the breed of choice.

On the big day, your dog will be exposed to strangers and most especially to a judge who will be doing a "go over". This will cause stress both to and your dog if he is not used to strangers touching him. This can be resolved by letting fellow dog owners and friends do a "go over" with your dog as this will make him more comfortable with strangers and ease the stress it will experience.

Some areas or places offer activities that will allow you and your puppy to meet other puppies and dogs. There are also socializing classes wherein your puppy or dog could learn some

things like the do's and don'ts of the ring training. Such activities and classes could help improve your dog's manners and new friendships arise from such.

Don't hesitate to ask for help regarding your puppy. Ask your local vet for help or information as to how to prepare your puppy for the big show. Also, your veterinarian could give you advice as to the proper grooming of your puppy. Judges are very particular in the appearance and grooming of pets in the dog show. How your puppy looks, their expressions are being judged so it is vital that you have enough info to make your puppy impress the judge.

Try inviting some friends and check out the activities that the training clubs you're in. If they have matches, why not join as this will help you and your puppy become familiar with the actual dog show. You could learn a lot from these activities and will be of great aid to your training for the big day.

Remember, champion dogs and handler were not made overnight. They were in fact in the same situation as you are perhaps years ago. The only thing is that they practiced and were patient enough never to give up.

About the Handlers

Not everyone can be a dog handler. Dog handlers are people who undergo specialized training and have the skills in the given field. These dog handlers are often times the ones we see during a dog show who present the dogs to the judges. They are professionals who render their service to dog owners. The handlers' responsibilities differ with each owner. Some may have to train dogs while some would just simply handle trained dogs. Likewise they are also in charge in the grooming of the dogs.

Dog handlers are not only found in dog shows. We find them in the military and police force. They are as important as the dogs they handle. Often times, they are in action assisting the military men and policemen look for carefully hidden bombs and drugs. They too are at risk as most drug dealers and terrorists target the dog and its handler.

Aside from being bomb sniffing dogs, the handlers also train and handle dogs used in rescue missions. In times of calamities, we could see teams of handlers and dogs scouring the entire city looking for survivors. These handlers are also knowledgeable in first aide procedures and techniques.

Then, is the issue of the handicapped. The dogs are trained to assist the handicapped and most common example is the blind dogs used by the blind. The dogs are most commonly called 'guide dogs'. They are allowed to bring the dogs in side premises that often do allow pets.

Even in ranches the dog handlers could be found. Not only do they handle and train dogs they also manage livestock with the aid of the stock dogs. Stock dogs are breeding specific thus not all dogs could be stock dogs. These dogs, under the training of the handler who often are the owners themselves, assist in managing cattle, ducks and geese. Pretty much they are all living inside the farm.

Lastly, some dog handlers work as volunteers for those people who need therapy. Some call them comfort. Most often the dogs could be found with their handlers at the old homes, at hospitals and anyone who needs their service.

Great care and attention is provided all the time by the handlers to their dogs and the bond between them is unbreakable.

Common Terminologies

Like all sporting events, dog shows have their own unique set of rules and terminology. The following is a helpful list of terms associated with the sport.

- **Angulations** - Angles created by bones meeting at their joints.
- **Armband** - The number worn on the handler's left arm that corresponds to the number listed in the official show catalogue
- **Bait** - The food or object the handler uses to focus the dog's attention or to have it look alert in the ring.
- **Bench show** - A dog show at which the dogs are kept on assigned benches when not being shown in competition, so they can be viewed and discussed by attendees, exhibitors, and breeders.
- **Best of Breed** - The dog judged as the best representative of the breed.
- **Best of Variety** - Award given in lieu of Best of Breed for those breeds divided by varieties. There are nine breeds divided by variety: Cocker Spaniels, Beagles, Dachshunds, Bull Terriers, Manchester Terriers, Chihuahuas, English Toy Spaniels, Poodles, and Collies.
- **Best of Winners** - The dog judged as best between the Winners Dog and the Winners Bitch.
- **Best of Opposite Sex** - The best dog that is of the opposite sex to the Best of Breed Winner.
- **Breed Standard** - Official written description of the ideal dog of each AKC-recognized breed, as specified by the breed's parent club. Includes characteristics that allow the breed

to perform the function for which it was bred and outlines the structure, form, movement, coat, and temperament of the breed. Dog show judging is a comparison of dogs to this established standard.

- **Bred-by-Exhibitor Class** - A regular class for dogs that are owned or co-owned by one of the breeders and shown by one of the breeders or a member of the breeder's immediate family.
- **Breeder** - A breeder of a particular dog is the person who owned the dam (mother) at the time she was bred to produce that dog.
- **Breeder-Owner-Handler** - Someone who exhibits, owns, and handles the dog they bred.
- **Catalogue** - Official listing of all dogs entered in the show, categorized by breed. Each breed is divided first by sex for class judging of non-champions. Next, champions are listed in the Best of Breed class. The catalogue assigns each dog a number and follows with the dog's name, AKC registration number, date of birth, parentage, and ownership.
- **Catalogue Order** - Ordering of the dogs in the ring for preliminary class judging in the order they appear listed in the catalogue.
- **Champion** - An AKC title conferred upon a dog that has earned 15 points in competition as a result of defeating a specified number of dogs at a series of AKC dog shows.
- **Conformation** - The form, structure, shape, and arrangement of the parts of a dog, as they relate and conform to the written standard of the breed.
- **Conformation Dog Show** - An event held under AKC rules where championship points are awarded. The purpose is to allow breeders to evaluate the success of their breeding program, with the goal of achieving structure and temperament necessary for the breed's function and to evaluate dogs for use as future breeding stock.
- **Exhibitor** - Someone whose dog is entered and shown at a dog show.
- **Expression** - The general appearance of all features of the head.
- **Fancy** - The group of people who are especially interested in purebred dogs or in a specific breed. Fanciers usually are active in the sport of purebred dogs.
- **Feathering** - Longer fringe hair on ears, tail, or body.
- **Field Trial** - Competition for certain Hounds or Sporting breeds in which dogs are judged on their ability and style in finding or retrieving game or following a game trail.
- **Gait** - Pattern of movement of the dog. Can be described as gallop, trot, walk, or hackney. Gait is a good indicator of structure, temperament, and condition.

- **Groups** - All AKC-recognized breeds are a member of one of seven groups: Sporting (dogs developed for the hunting of feathered game); Hound (dogs commonly used for hunting by sight or scent); Working (dogs used to pull carts, guard property, and for search and rescue work); Terrier (dogs originally used to hunt vermin); Toy (dogs characterized by very small size); Non-Sporting (diverse group of multi-functional dogs not generally regarded to be game hunters); and Herding (group of dogs whose main duty is to drive livestock from one place to another).
- **Grooming** - Making the dog's appearance adhere to the standard by bathing, brushing, combing, trimming, etc.
- **Handler** - A person or agent who takes a dog into the show ring or who works the dog at a field trial or other performance.
- **Heel** - A command to a dog to keep close beside its handler.
- **Judge** - An official approved by the AKC to judge dogs at AKC events.
- **Junior Handler** - Person between the ages of 10 and 18 who competes in an AKC-sponsored class called Junior Showmanship. Junior handlers are judged on their ability to show and handle their dog, not on the quality of the dog.
- **Match show** - A usually informal dog show at which no championship points are awarded.
- **Miscellaneous Class** - Transitional class for breeds attempting to advance in full AKC recognition.
- **Pedigree** - The written record of a dog's family tree of three or more generations.
- **Points** - Credits earned toward a championship.
- **Purebred** - A dog whose sire and dam belong to the same breed and are themselves of unmixed descent since the recognition of the breed.
- **Professional Handler** - Person who shows dogs for a fee.
- **Register** - To record a dog's parentage with the AKC.
- **Soundness** - Mental and physical well-being.
- **Stack** - To position the dog in a natural standing position or pose.
- **Type** - The characteristic qualities distinguishing a breed.

- **Winners** - An award given to the best dog (Winners Dog) and best bitch (Winners Bitch) competing in regular classes. The Winners are the only dogs of that breed who are awarded championship points on that day.

Conclusion

Now that you read and learned about show dogs and their training, it is advisable to memorize what you have just read. Also, expert advises given by local vets and club members as well as dog owners are extremely vital when we want the best show dogs.

Just like any animal, one must remember that careful planning must be made. Before anything else, show dog rising is not an easy task. The success of raising dogs depends upon the dog owner and its passion to raise and train the dog. The training must not be scary for the dog but it should be positive for both the dog and the dog owner.

These dogs have specific needs that only pet owners could provide. Their health and nutrition must not be overlooked. Careful observation of their attitude tells a lot as to how they are feeling and the condition that they are in. Proper nutrition is very important most especially since it affects their coat condition. Dull coats could mean they are under nourished or deprived of the essential nutrients. It never hurts to invest in your dogs grooming and equipments. After all these help in making your shows dog the best in his field.

When entering a show, know as much as you can with the event, the breeds and the handlers. It would be great if you could be a step ahead of them as they will be your competitors once you enter that ring. It becomes a whole new world once you are in there.

To wrap things up, nothings beats a show dog owner who has prepared for the event for months and developed techniques in training the dog. When you enter the ring, you should have only one goal, to win that highest award. And when you, there is no greater feeling than receiving that award.

Remember, at the end of all the trainings and contests, the real winners are you and your dog. Pat yourself for a job well done.